Common Ground

Our new link — what changes for you, in plain English

A proposal for discussion · CEA link from 1 January 2027 · 26 weeks · code CG-26-T8

The short version

Five things to take away if you remember nothing else

35h	5	14	30	30 min
the contracted week, as now	**most days in a row**	**full weekends off a year**	**days off for 14 days' leave**	**off every closing shift**
no extra hours	up to 7 · today 7–9	today 10 · 7 in 26	at best · as today	up to 1 hour

Same hours, shorter closers, 30 days off for 14 days' leave as now, and never more than five days in a row, cover weeks aside.

Why the link has to change

Nobody is changing it for the sake of it

A new timetable in December 2026

More trains, at new times — the new link follows from 1 January 2027.

More of us on the link

It grows from 20 weeks to 26, so six more colleagues join it.

New staffing levels

At least 10 on a Sunday, and more at the close and at 22:00. We also aim for 14 on a Saturday.

The ticket office in fixed pairs

Two early and two late, on the same shifts, every day.

The change is coming whatever we do — the question is which version we want.

Will I work more?

The first thing everyone asks

	Today	Common Ground
Contracted hours a week	35h	**35h**
Contracted days at work a week	4.20	**4.19**
Contracted days at work a year	219.0	**218.6**

No. The same 35-hour week on average; weeks run 25h 30m–42h 30m Monday to Saturday (today 25h 10m–43h 50m), and two more days a year are Saturdays.

Will my basic pay change?

Basic pay follows your contracted hours — and a swap for a late earns less overtime

	Today	Common Ground
Contracted hours a week	35h	**35h**
Saturdays a year, at time and a quarter	26	**28**
Sunday overtime to share — each, a year	21	**20**
A late against an early, same day, on average	32 min longer	**12 min longer**
Finishing at 13:35 or 13:45 — each, a year	26	**12**

No: basic pay stays the same. Premium and overtime pay come to about £350 a year less, gross, if you work your share of Sundays. That assumes no swap overtime.

Will my shifts be longer?

Closing shifts get shorter, earlies longer — the average goes up about two minutes

	Today	Common Ground
Weekday closer — starts 15:45, not 15:15	8h 40m	**8h 10m**
Saturday closer — starts 15:45, not 14:45	9h 10m	**8h 10m**
Sunday closer — starts 15:15, not 14:30	8h 55m	**8h 10m**
Average early, Monday to Saturday	7h 59m	**8h 09m**
Average late, Monday to Saturday	8h 29m	**8h 21m**
Average shift, Monday to Saturday	8h 14m	**8h 16m**

Every closing shift is 30 to 60 minutes shorter; nothing Monday to Friday runs over 8h 30m, and nothing at all over 9 hours.

Will I finish late more often?

3 more a year at 23:00 or later (42, today 39); 16 more at 22:00 or later (94, today 78)

	Today	Common Ground
Finishing at 23:00 or later — each, a year	39	**42**
Finishing at 22:00 or later — each, a year	78	**94**
Starting at 06:20 — each, a year	62	**48**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	**14h 35m**

More people stay on after 22:00 under the December staffing; the three more at 23:00 or later are the fewest the rules allow.

Will I know the times?

14 shift times in all — 7 of them you already work

You work these today (7)

06:20–13:45
06:20–14:20
06:20–14:50
08:00–16:30
11:00–19:30
14:00–22:30
14:30–22:00

New times (7)

- Closers start later: 30 minutes on weekdays, an hour on Saturdays, 45 minutes on Sundays
- A new early, 07:00–15:30, and a 9-hour Saturday late, 13:30–22:30
- On Sundays: 07:15–15:30, 09:00–17:30 and the ticket-office late, 14:30–22:30

Fewer shift times than today (14, not 18) — and today's 13:45 and 14:20 finishes stay.

Rest and weekends

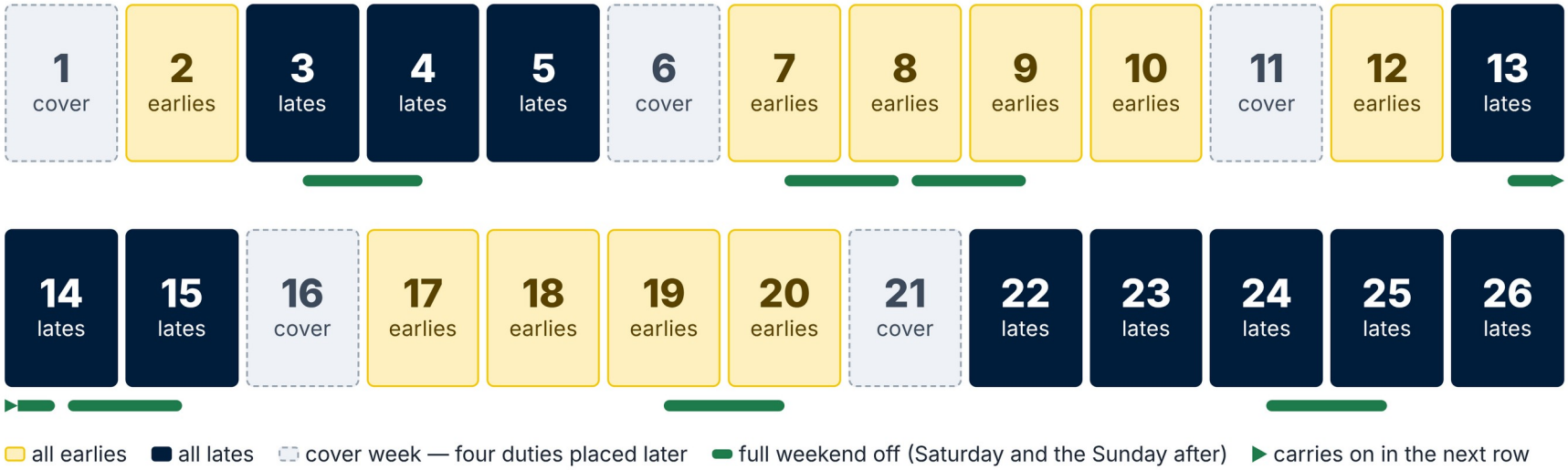
The biggest improvement over today

	Today	Common Ground
Full weekends off, about a year	10	**14**
Most days worked in a row	7 (up to 9)	**5 (up to 7)**
Rest-day breaks of two days or more	13 of 17	**20 of 26**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	**14h 35m**
Weeks on one shift time, Monday to Friday	7 of 16	**19 of 21**

14 full weekends off a year, at most five weeks apart, and never more than five days in a row, cover weeks aside.

Your 26 weeks at a glance

The green bars are the full weekends off; where you start is decided later



Blocks of earlies or lates up to 5 weeks, 7 if the cover weeks go the same way; a full weekend off comes round at least every 5 weeks.

Booking leave

What 14 days of annual leave buys you, with Sundays off

	Today	Common Ground
Days off in a row — best place to book	30	**30**
Days off in a row — on average	23.4	**23.4**
Days off in a row — worst place	19	**20**
Leave for four full weeks off, at best	14	**14**

As today: 14 days' leave buys up to 30 days off, and four full weeks off in a row, Sunday to Saturday, take 14 days' leave. Average the same, worst a day better.

More staff on the floor

More people rostered every day, more at 22:00, and more at the close on most days

	Today	Common Ground
On duty on a weekday	11–12	**15**
On duty on a Saturday / Sunday	10 / 8	**14 / 10**
Fewest rostered on the floor	2	**3**
Avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside	4 (up to 5)	**0 (up to 1)**

At least three rostered on the floor, and no avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside.

The honest trade-offs

Nothing is free — here is what it costs

Seven new shift times to learn
Three shorter lates, a new 07:00 early, a 9-hour Saturday late and two Sunday earlies.

Earlies or lates in longer runs
Up to 5 weeks of one kind, 7 if the cover weeks go the same way (today 2, up to 3).

More single rest days
Six in 26 weeks, about 12 a year each (today about 10).

Two more Saturdays a year
28 a year each, today 26 — fourteen on a Saturday, shared across 26 lines.

More late finishes
42 a year each at 23:00 or later (today 39), and 94 at 22:00 or later (today 78).

Fewer early finishes
12 a year each finish before 14:00 (today 26).

None of these is hidden: every figure here is worked out from the rota.

At a glance

Same hours and days, shorter closers, more weekends off, fewer days in a row

	Today	Common Ground
Contracted hours a week	35h	35h
Contracted days at work a year	219.0	218.6
Average shift · longest shift	8h 14m · 9h 10m	8h 16m · 9h 00m
Closing shift: weekday · Saturday · Sunday	8h 40m · 9h 10m · 8h 55m	**8h 10m · 8h 10m · 8h 10m**
Full weekends off, about a year	10	**14**
Most days worked in a row	7 (up to 9)	**5 (up to 7)**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	14h 35m
Different shift times	18	14 (7 you know)
On duty weekday · Saturday · Sunday	11–12 · 10 · 8	15 · 14 · 10
Avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside	4 (up to 5)	0 (up to 1)

The costs: more late finishes, more single rest days and longer runs of earlies or lates.

What happens next

1. Look at the full proposal sheet — page 3 shows every week of the link
2. Tell us what worries you, even if it is small
3. Your feedback goes to the managers with the proposal